The Truman Doctrine

President Harry S. Truman · March 12, 1947

Source: Harry S. Truman, Address Before a Joint Session of Congress (1947). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> Asking Congress to aid Greece and Turkey against communist pressure, Truman committed the United States to containing the spread of communism — the guiding principle of American Cold War foreign policy.

At the present moment in world history nearly every nation must choose between alternative ways of life. The choice is too often not a free one. One way of life is based upon the will of the majority, and is distinguished by free institutions, representative government, free elections, guarantees of individual liberty, freedom of speech and religion, and freedom from political oppression. The second way of life is based upon the will of a minority forcibly imposed upon the majority. It relies upon terror and oppression, a controlled press and radio; fixed elections, and the suppression of personal freedoms. I believe that it must be the policy of the United States to support free peoples who are resisting attempted subjugation by armed minorities or by outside pressures. I believe that we must assist free peoples to work out their own destinies in their own way. I believe that our help should be primarily through economic and financial aid which is essential to economic stability and orderly political processes.